

A thing to take note of is the fact that the keyboard doesn't have the tab and escape keys due to lack of space. However, these are vital when you're using a shell. I'm not surprised that the developers didn't fail to take notice of the fact and enabled these as part of X Term's UI.

Using the root shell you can peep into the / directory to see what's in there (Figure 29). The N900 comes with a 32GB storage as we know. Let's see how the device is partitioned after installing the *cfdisk* utility—take a look at Figure 30. The storage is divided into three partitions—approx 29GB vfat for your own storage; approx 2GB of ext3 root partition, which is enough to install a lot of apps; and around 800MB of swap space (that adds up to the 256MB of RAM to give you a gigabyte of total memory). Of course, you can check the availability of space using a graphical tool from within the device, too (Figure 31).

Multitasking and performance

Well, I shall conclude with this section. Although, I probably, haven't even covered 50 per cent of what the Maemo and the N900 combo offers, I've run out of space and time :-)

Multitasking is a pleasure here. You can listen to your music, chat with multiple buddies over GTalk or SMS, browse the Web, work on a document using AbiWord, etc—all simultaneously. And you can switch between these apps seamlessly using the wonderful Dashboard application. The 600Mhz OMAP processor is powerful enough to take care of this sort of a load. However, sometimes I did experience a lag in response time when too many apps were open—and I'm talking more than eight here. It makes me wonder: what would happen if the next version of the device comes with 512 MB of RAM and a processor clock speed of 1GHz (to match the Nexus One).

On the down side, I'd have preferred a battery with a higher capacity. 1350mAh is just not enough for the kind of multitasking we can do on the N900, and I saw the battery ran out of power within 6-8 hours of continuous usage. Thankfully, the USB cable doubles up as a charger when connected to a computer, so you don't have to carry your charger separately everywhere you go.

Overall, I'd suggest the N900 to anyone who loves GNU/Linux. Android is not really for them—you can't really get into the system internals on that as easily as this one. The pricing and the launch dates in India are still a mystery. But if we go by the European prices, an unlocked N900 should come for anything between Rs30,000-Rs35,000. **END** 

Resources and useful links

- Nokia's Maemo website: <http://maemo.nokia.com>
- Maemo.org community: <http://maemo.org>
- Maemo.org Wiki: http://wiki.maemo.org/Main_Page
- Maemo.org forum: <http://talk.maemo.org>
- App reviews and how-tos: www.maemo-guru.com

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Figure 30: N900's partition table



Figure 31: How much space is available



Figure 32: The Conky system monitor application



Figure 33: Playing TuxRacer